Unusual Normality

By Ishmael Beah

ISHMAEL: I came to New York City in 1998. I was seventeen. I entered the United States with just a passport in my hand, because somehow the baggage that I'd checked when I boarded the flight from the Ivory Coast (which was tattered in ways unimaginable) didn't make it.

I stood there watching all these huge bags go by, and mine didn't come. This bag held all my possessions at this point: two pairs of pants and two shirts-one long-sleeved and one short. So I just started laughing, and I didn't even bother going to the lost-baggage section to claim it. I just walked right out to meet my new adoptive mother, who was standing there with a beaming smile, waiting for me.

INTRODUCTION

From 1991 to 2002, Sierra Leone was embroiled in a devastating civil war, which garnered international attention for its blatant use of child soldiers. Children, some as young as 7 years old, made up between 40 and 50 percent of the Revolutionary force and approximately 20 percent of the government's military. Approximately 10-14 thousand children were exploited and forced to be child soldiers in Sierra Leone.

Ishmael Beah's parents and two brothers were killed and he was forcibly recruited into the war at age 13. After two years, with UNICEF help, he was removed from the army and placed in a rehabilitation home in Freetown. Mr. Beah later became UNICEF's first Advocate for Children Affected by War. He has vowed to do everything in his power to . . . "make sure that what happened to me doesn't continue to happen to other children around the world." This is his story.

Unusual Normality by Ishmael Beah

ISHMAEL: I had come to the United States. To have a new home, and to live with a mother who was willing to take me into her life when most people at the time

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

were afraid of somebody like me. It was a chance at living again, because all I had come to know, since I was eleven, was how to survive. I didn't know how to live. All I knew, really, up until this point in my life, was struggle. This was what I had come to expect from life, and I didn't trust in happiness or any kind of normality at all.

So here I was in New York, with my new mother. We needed to step into that normality. But we had a lot of things to deal with, and one of the most pressing ones was that I needed to get into school. You see, the visa that I had been given was a prospective-student visa. This meant that when I arrived in the United States, I had three months to get into a school. If I didn't, I would be returned to my war-torn country, Sierra Leone.

When I went to some of the interviews, I was immediately denied because of the following conversation: "Do you have a report card to show that you had been in school?" I would say, "No." And then my mother would interject to explain the context. I would sit there thinking to myself, What do these school principals think? Do they really think that when there's a war in your village and people are gunned down in front of you, and you 're running for your life, you're thinking to yourself, "You know, I must take my report card and put it in the back of my pocket."

I was [finally] accepted to the United Nations International School. Thus began my two years of high school and making other teenagers confused about who I was. You see, I didn't fit into any box. I didn't have the same worries about what shoes or clothes I wore. And of course, I couldn't tell them, because I felt that they were not ready to hear the truth. What was I going to say? "Hey, you know, I was a child soldier at thirteen." So I was silent, mostly. And this made them more curious.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

They would say to me, "You're such a weird kid." And I would respond by saying, "No. I'm not weird. Weird has a negative connotation. I prefer the word unusual." When I was finished saying this, they would look at me and say, "Why don't you speak like a normal person?" They thought maybe my English was like this because I was from some royal African family.

But I needed to be silent about my background, because I also felt like I was being watched. When I got into the school, some of the other parents were not very happy that somebody with my background was in school with their children. And I realized that the way I conducted myself would determine whether they would ever let another child who had been through war into such a school.

These kids were tough (they told me). Because they lived in a tough city, New York. And therefore, they were tough. They had gotten into fights and won. So they would say things to me like, "If you want to survive the streets of New York City, we need to teach you a few things." And I would say, "Well, thank you very much. I truly appreciate this advice that you're giving me."

Truth was, I'd been to some of these places that they spoke about, these neighborhoods, and I knew that the people who lived there didn't glorify violence the way they did. They didn't have time to pretend, because they lived in it, just like I had. I noticed that these kids had an ***idea*** of violence that they'd never really lived. They glorified it in a way, because they'd never actually experienced it at all.

When I walked with them, I observed that I paid more attention to the people who walked past us. I didn't take the same route twice, because I didn't want to develop a predictable path. These were all habits that were formed from my experiences, but I noticed that my new friends didn't do

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

that. So I knew they were just saying these things to seem tough to me. I wished that the only violence I knew was the violence that I imagined.

After about a year of being friends with these boys, one of them decided to invite a group of us to upstate New York. His family had property up there, and we were going to play a game called paintball.

"You use these balls of paint, and you shoot people," and he explained the basics of the game to me. And I thought, if these guys who only ***pretend*** about violence can play it, it must not be that difficult a game.

As soon as we arrived, I began to memorize the terrain immediately. I knew how many paces it took to get to the house, how many paces it took to the first tree, to the first bush, to the shed. And this was all out of habit, because where I came from, in my previous life, this kind of skill set could determine whether you lived or died.

They showed me the weapon, how you shoot it. And I allowed them to teach me to shoot things. They were very macho about it. They said to me, "This is how you shoot, you aim like this." I said, "Okay." I tried it a few times. I deliberately missed. Then they showed me the camouflage and the combat gear.

"Yeah, we're gonna go out! We're gonna DO THIS!!" They started painting their faces, getting into this ***idea*** of war that they knew. I declined putting the face paint on. (Beat) So we went off into the bush, and when one of them shouted, "Yeah, let the war begin! I'm going to bring pain to all of you! I'm going to show you how it's done!" I thought to myself: First rule of warfare, you **never** belittle your opponent. But I didn't say this. I went into the bushes.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I would hide. I would wait for them. And they would come rolling around, jumping, doing all kinds of things, things they'd probably seen in movies about how people act in war. And after they were done exhausting themselves, I would come up behind them, and I would shoot them.

This went on all day. And when we came back that night, they talked about it. "How come you're so good? You're sure you've never played paintball before?

"I grew up in a village. And I used to be a hunter when I was a boy, so I know how to blend into the forest, like a chameleon. I know how to adapt to my environment."

They wanted to beat me, and so they started to team up with each other. I would see them doing this, and then I would come up with a kind of watered-down version of another guerrilla tactic. I would walk backwards and then stand where my footsteps "began" and hide. They would follow my footprints, and then I would come up behind them.

When I returned, I told my mother about this game. And my mother, being a mother, was immediately worried. "Oh, did that bring up something for you?"

"No, it didn't, absolutely." Because I know the difference between ***pretend*** war and ***real*** war.

They never invited me back to play paintball with them. And I didn't ask to be invited back. I had so wanted to talk to them about the war while we were playing the game. I wanted to explain certain things, but I felt that if they knew about my background, they would fear me.

It was only years later that they learned why I had won the game. But I wish I had been able to tell them early on, because I wanted them to understand how lucky they were to have a mother, a father, grandparents, siblings.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

People who annoyed them by caring about them so much and calling them all the time to make sure they were okay.

They were so lucky to have this naive innocence about the world. I wanted them to understand that it was extremely lucky for them to only ***play*** war and never have to do the ***real*** thing.

[Because] their naive innocence about the world was something for which I no longer had the capacity.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ishmael Beah
Book: The Moth Presents All These Wonders
ISBN: 978-1101904404
Publisher: Crown Archetype
Date (Month/Year): March 2017

AWARD HISTORY

2018 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY